

Our Home

An Introduction

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I.

The word *home* calls up associations of intimacy, fullness, and rest. Of intimacy — for although the home, viewed from outside, is a place like all other places, it is for us the place where we received everything that fate brought us: the inlet to which the effects of the great ocean of the outer world had to find their way before we could feel and appreciate them. And it is equally the place from which the effects we ourselves have exercised have gone forth. In all our acting and suffering, all our giving and receiving, the mood of home therefore weaves itself in and forms a background of which we perhaps first become clearly conscious when it is threatened with dissolution, or when it undergoes some deeper change. And with this the fullness is also connected. For it is a large circle of memories and habits — indeed, the whole content of our life — that coheres with this central idea. Home is like the net that cannot be drawn up without a swarm of living content following with it. Rest, finally, depends on both intimacy and fullness. Rest cannot be found in the foreign and the new, only in what is known and tried, and whose appropriation requires no exertion. What is homely is fitted to the forms of our nature; every fold and joint in our being finds there a resting place that suits it. When what is homely surfaces again for us, it is as though it had never been away; easily and quickly we settle back into the long-since-fitted frame. And the wealth of habits and memories that home bears also brings rest. One cannot rest on a sharp

edge; there must be a manifoldness in the content if continual dwelling on one and the same thing is not to tire and dull.

One has a home as soon as one has something to lay one's head against. Home presupposes fixedness, constancy, repetition. What is homely stands in opposition to the new, the foreign, and the shifting. When the fox has its lair and the bird its nest, they have a home. They have something to return to, something that waits for them, something that can be recognized and that stands firm through the surge of change. We therefore also have a home in our own inner life when the content of our consciousness does not shift without interruption, but we have fundamental thoughts and fundamental moods that constitute our spiritual standpoint and condition the effect that new experiences have on us — indeed, that are the very precondition for anything being able to appear as new to us. Into the circle of these fundamental thoughts and moods everything must be received that we would genuinely call our spiritual possession.

It is more than an arbitrary comparison that we draw here when we place the outer, material home and the inner, spiritual home alongside each other. For they both rest on the same physiological and psychological conditions. Life cannot persist without a rhythm in its inner and outer relations. Intake and output, inhalation and exhalation, rest and movement must alternate with one another if life is to persist. A return to the same states is therefore an organic condition of life. And spiritually, the course of life requires fixed points of departure and orientation, stable background-states against which experiences can stand out in their distinctiveness — yet in such a way that a common measure becomes possible.

II.

In the human world, home and family belong closely together. Yet there can be a home where there is no family. The solitary person can have a home, and at the lowest levels of human life known to us, the family has not yet separated itself from the horde or clan as a distinct community. The wandering horde returns by preference to the places that offer sustenance and security, and in any case carries its tents and utensils along as constituents of a travelling home. Already here home means intimacy, fullness, and rest. The struggle for life, which is a struggle against the foreign, comes to a halt in the tent and on the familiar pastures and hunting grounds. And memories already play a role when one moves through the same regions where one's ancestors moved. Even if one has no fixed dwelling places otherwise, the graves of one's forebears will be a

center around which one circles and for which one takes up the fight, even when one offers no resistance against pressing foreign forces elsewhere. Already here, then, home undergoes the significant metamorphosis from being a material necessity to becoming an ideal value. What from the beginning was only a physical refuge can later become the only place where life seems worth living, because it can there alone be lived in continuity with the life of the past, as a continuation of it.

Of the greatest significance in the history of home was the development of the family into a distinct kind of community. The core of the family is the bond between mother and child. These two hold together and have their home with each other, however things may stand with the family's other elements. Here a natural connection is at work — not merely the connection conditioned by the satisfaction of the need for sustenance and security in the same places. Birth is an extension of organic growth beyond the individual organism. Home thus grows, literally. In many parts of the world one finds, at a certain stage of development, the arrangement by which husband and wife continue to belong to their respective tribes, and the children belong to the wife's tribe, not the husband's. What has created the family as we now know it — as a community of husband, wife, and children — has been partly the man's will to power and self-assertion, and partly the fixed dwelling. The man regarded the woman and the children she had borne him as his property; he wished to make use of the labor they possessed, and he felt a need to see his lineage continued in his offspring. The fixed dwelling and the regular shared life it brought about provided a foundation for custom and usage, for tradition and memory, and there was now more occasion for the arising of tenderer feelings. Shared life softened, underpinned, and humanized the animal impulse and the crude will to power. The common hearth became sacred, for the spirits of the ancestors visited it continually. And in this sanctuary even the foreign guest — even if he were an enemy — found a place of refuge. A sanctuary had been created whose spirit could spread to wider circles.

The family, at its most primitive level, is only a means for the continuation and perpetuation of life. But even here, interests and motives of a different kind from those that originally founded the bond begin to form. It is then not only sustenance, security, and the continuation of the lineage that are sought; the mood of home that the fixed dwelling and the shared traditions engender becomes valuable in itself, stands as an immediate good in which the human being wishes to live. A common fate and common labor continually consolidate the feeling of belonging together. Even if the natural bond only comes fully into view in the relation between mother and child, bonds are woven

between all the members of the family in the course of their shared life that can often rival the merely physical connection in strength.

Even after the family has separated itself from the horde or clan and has become a community in its own right, sustained by its own distinctive forces, it does not yet stand in the opposition to other kinds of community that we know from modern life. It has more purposes than the modern family, since it is at the same time a small state and a small church, a legal community and a cultural community in one. Paternal and parental authority holds sway as the highest power, and even where a state exists, the family threshold forms a boundary to its influence. Religion, which at this stage is the sum of all culture, is from the beginning the affair of the family: within the family the spirits of the deceased are venerated from generation to generation; the hearth-fire is kept burning in their honor, and their commands constitute the content of the moral law. Only under the advance of development does the family cease to have such wide-ranging purposes; the state draws all relations among individuals under its power and supervision, and distinct communities form for the cultivation of material and ideal culture. What then remains for the family is the tending of the first shoots of new human life, and of the intimate feelings that can bind human beings together apart from all cultural endeavors and all legal relations. This in no way diminishes the family's significance. On the contrary: the family relation, by virtue of its independence from all the differences and antagonisms that in wider circles divide human beings, and by virtue of its connection with the natural instincts that secure the continuation of the lineage, stands as the strongest and most intimate community — one that provides a measure for the development of all other communities. The more intimate and stronger other social bonds become, the more they are described in terms borrowed from the family's. In the family the individual can live according to his whole personality, whereas the cultural community and the state have use only for certain sides of his being. And the bond here is grounded in the unconscious natural life, whereas other communities rest on half- or wholly conscious purposes and interests.

Even where the division of labor brings about an opposition between the family on the one side and the cultural community and state on the other, the family therefore retains its significance — or indeed first comes fully into its own. It now becomes a central place where what is accomplished by work in the cultural community and state can be appreciated and enjoyed. And it becomes a nursery where the forces that are to work in the cultural community and state can germinate and grow. It represents intimacy, coherence, security, and rest, to which one can return again and again from

the outward-turned, divided, struggling, and strenuous activity in the wider circles.

III.

We have described home according to its ideal as well as according to its historical development. But it emerged that a great many different forces and conditions are presupposed if the ideal is to be reached here, and it is therefore to be expected that the ideal is not always reached. And if an old saying is right — that the better something is, the worse it becomes when corrupted — then we must expect that home under unfavorable conditions will oppress life just as much as it can advance life under fortunate ones.

Let us first examine somewhat more closely what the enduring significance and justification of home rests upon. The justification lies in a line of thought similar to the one that justifies the right and freedom of the individual personality. For the sake of society itself, the greatest possible independence and freedom of the individual must be secured. For in the individual's inner life lies the seed of everything new and great. The more vigorously life stirs there, the more vigorously it will be able to stir in the wider circles. Individual personalities are the source-points of society's life, just as they are the central places to which all effects originating from social life propagate themselves. There the value of life is felt, and from there proceed the endeavors that can enhance that value. Smaller and narrower communities stand in a similar relation to larger ones. Life is conducted and felt more strongly and intimately in the former than in the latter. What is not attended to, and what is not protected, in the wider circles finds attention and care in the smaller ones. For this reason the interests of the large communities — those of the state and the cultural community — themselves require that the smaller ones be maintained in their distinctiveness and independence. The significance of home is likewise grounded in the inverse relation between the strength and the scope of life. Already Aristotle, in his critique of Plato's *Republic* — where the family for the higher classes was to be abolished in favor of a universal kinship among all individuals — appealed to this law. It will, he says, become a diluted love that is supposed to unite all after the dissolution of the narrower and more intimate bonds; it will scarcely be perceptible, any more than the admixture of a little sugar in a large quantity of water makes an impression on the taste. It is perfectly correct, Aristotle continues, that the state should be a unity; but if one erases all difference and multiplicity, the state ceases to exist, just as the symphony ceases when only one voice is heard, and the rhythm when there is only a single verse-foot. — The great Greek philosopher of the state thereby

clearly demonstrated the significance of the small communities' existence within the large.

But in order to understand the doubts that may arise about the value of home, we must take note that the law of the inverse relation between strength and scope is not the only law governing the development of human interests. For in the domain of emotional life there also appears an inverse relation between strength and content. The content of a feeling is the representations to which it is attached, and which give it its distinctive character. Joy and sorrow are nuanced and varied according to the representational content that conditions them. Now it is clear that with narrow scope there also easily follows a narrow content. In the small circles, emotional life easily assumes a purely elementary character, coming to lack definite and many-sided formation. When isolated from life in the wider circles, there then easily enters — even if the strength of the feeling is preserved, which on account of the influence of habit and monotony does not always happen — a spiritual poverty. The feeling then becomes blind. The content it has, which is perhaps held fast with great intimacy and passion, derives essentially from the past. The household gods of the family are the heroes of bygone ages; but it is not given that they are suited to be guides in new times. The conservative character of home is conditioned by this. Intimacy, security, and rest then turn into inertia and engender reluctance and fear in the face of the new. What otherwise constitutes the strength of home here becomes its weakness. All ages of history offer experiences in this direction. Here we will draw attention only to a few particularly striking features. — A Japanese writer, Tokiwo Yokoi, recently undertook, on the occasion of the war between China and Japan, a comparison between the prevailing morality of the two peoples, and laid great stress on the fact that Chinese morality is essentially a family morality: “It was the principle of filial piety that formed the foundation of Chinese morality, rather than the principle of loyalty to the sovereign.” The Chinese ethical tradition was pushed all the more in this direction because dynasties in China have changed very frequently. The family bond then became the only bond that could uphold unity and continuity in society — and with such firmness that “these three hundred million people have preserved their traditions and customs unchanged for three thousand years and through twenty-three changes of dynasty.” But the virtues that distinguish the Chinese are therefore also only the virtues of private and domestic life, whereas patriotism, and integrity in public affairs, are lacking. This explains the difficulty of taking up and carrying through reforms in China, while the Japanese, who through long ages had been practiced in subordinating private and domestic interests to the demands of the state, threw themselves onto the

path of progress with the greatest zeal and self-sacrifice. — Discerning observers of conditions in Turkey and Persia have found that the oriental harems perhaps offer the most important resistance to the penetration of a new culture. “While there,” says Vambéry (*Der Islam des neunzehnten Jahrhunderts*), “in the Selamlık (the part of the house accessible to men and the outside world) signs of renewal appear here and there, and *à la franca* has so to speak become a watchword, in the harem, the sanctuary of the Muhammadan family, everything has remained as it was, and not the slightest change has occurred in the furnishings, customs, and household order, any more than in dress, manner of speech, and habits of thought... Among some hardened Orthodox, the harem has in reality become a happy refuge, while it is of course a tremendous impediment to those champions of the new who are in earnest. What is introduced in the Selamlık is either ignored in the harem or torn down again by unbridled fanaticism.” — Tendencies in a similar direction are not lacking in Europe. One has thus — both in Protestant and in Catholic countries — advanced the claim that the school should be dependent on the home. “Home, state, and church,” said Bishop Ketteler, “must have schools that correspond to their spirit and their demands.” What is missing here is the supplementary proposition that the school — in the widest sense: the community for the advancement and appropriation of science — must in turn act back upon the spirit and the demands that prevail in home, state, and church; that there is a wider horizon than the home’s (and the other communities’) tendency toward closure easily leads it to restrict. The often close and stale air of home needs to be cleansed by fresh currents. In such cases one is not in fact fighting for the home, but using the home as a means of preserving dogmas that cannot be maintained in any other way. But the cultural content on which the home is to draw will by this procedure become poorer and will congeal in dead forms.

It will in the long run not be possible to preserve strength and intimacy when the content shrinks in this way. Repetition will exercise its deadening power, and spiritual death will be the final effect. All living feeling presupposes for its persistence rhythm and opposition; where there is nothing new to discover at all, feeling passes over into passive habit. The character and value of home will therefore depend on the richness in the nature of the people who constitute it. The more distinctive and many-sided each of them is, the more favorable will be the conditions for new discoveries within the narrow circle, and the more independent the home will be able to become of the wide world, without losing life and freshness.

But it is precisely not always the case that the individual personality finds in the home the right conditions for its development, or meets with the understanding without which

its distinctiveness cannot unfold. In the home it is naturally the common that holds sway. The natural ground that sustains the family holds the individual individualities fixed in their still-undetermined form; in the more determinate formation of the individual individuality there lies a possibility that the immediate connection and the instinctive mutual understanding will cease. A reluctance to break with the shared life naturally arises — to turn aside from the customary tracks along which the familiar, unwritten-law-governed outlook guides the members of the family — and the individual is easily impeded thereby in his independent development. In its most prosaic form, this reluctance appears as shyness. A peculiar kind of self-consciousness that comes into force over against those nearest, but can fall away over against those more distantly placed. This relation forms an analogy to the fact that the feeling of love, at higher levels of human life, does not awaken within the sibling relationship but requires a new and foreign object to be aroused. Only in the face of the new and foreign does individuality come fully forth. Add to this that within the circle of home both the unfortunate and the fortunate elements of character can thrive. What is easily worn smooth in contact with the less indulgent foreign world can, under the mild and soft conditions of home, spread and draw attention away from what is essential and valuable. In any case, within the home the petty and the great often emerge in obscure mixtures that make both overestimation and underestimation possible. Now the individual is regarded without justification as a prophet by those nearest to him; now he is not respected as a prophet, though he is one.

IV.

The future of home will depend on whether the dangers pointed out here can be avoided. If home is to uphold its value for human life, it must enter into an open and positive relation to the wider communities and the interests stirring in them, and it must also within its own circle bring about the most favorable possible conditions for the distinctive development of its individual members. Home can be attacked from two sides: from the socialist side as isolating, from the anarchist side as inhibiting. Human development moves at once in the direction of wider horizons and more universal spheres of activity, and in the direction of a more determinate formation of individual distinctiveness.

But there is no reason to think that home will not be able to meet the tasks set before it. It has hitherto followed the human being along the long road from animal rawness to social and spiritual human life, and even if the household gods change — and may perhaps change more frequently in the future than before — their place will not come to

stand empty.

It is a natural necessity that we live in a small world before the large one can become real for us. And the more the home truly is itself a small world, the more can life there become a preparatory school for life in the wide world — while at the same time preserving its independent value as the place of intimacy and security. There is something common to every world, be it small or large. A common law holds sway and determines the place and activity of the individual elements; each individual element must subordinate itself to the order of the whole, yet is also animated by the bonding forces that hold the whole together. Within the family, the individual unconsciously grows into the idea that he is one among many; he comes to know self-surrender, resignation, and justice; and without noise, without any painful resistance needing to be felt, the unbridled expression of his egotism is restrained. The first objects of fear and love, of admiration and gratitude, of esteem and reverence, he finds within the circle of home.

Even within the small world — when it does not isolate itself — the individual will have experiences of the significance of larger relations. The swell from the ocean of the world often carries into the quiet inlet of home. National misfortunes, for example, touch the child early through the sorrow they awaken in the elders; to its amazement it sees that what happens in the distance affects those nearest, as though it were their own weal and woe at stake. The first feeling of belonging to a larger whole than that constituted by parents and siblings, family and friends, is perhaps laid down in such a moment. Through its relation to the first objects of its love and admiration, the child unconsciously grows into the interests for which these, its models, already live. But the elders stand not only as intermediaries between the child and the wider circles of interest. They also stand as intermediaries between the past and the future. Their task is not merely to transmit the values of the past, but also to prepare those of the future. Home has here the great significance of bridging the different generations and making possible an understanding between them that would be excluded if the new generation did not grow up within the older one and under the influence of the most immediate and most naturally determined sympathy that can in general bind human beings together. The struggle between the old and the new would be sharper and also less fruitful if it were not prepared in subdued form within the walls of home.

There are also within home the most favorable conditions for personal development, especially in the period when the forms are still undetermined and many shoots are putting forth that are perhaps not viable, yet cannot be forcibly cut away without danger

to life. There further lies in the nature of sympathy, as it can appear within home, an interest in and a capacity for understanding purely individual stirrings, which is excluded only under unfavorable circumstances, when blindness and limitation come to hold sway. In any case, individual distinctiveness will scarcely find such favorable conditions for life as here. Greater demands will also in this respect be placed on the home of the future. It is after all now — to bring forward a single important point — not only the man whose personality demands free scope for individual distinctiveness. The same demand is now being raised for women as well. Women now wish not only, as could also happen in earlier ages — in the Renaissance period, for instance — a share in the general education and in the thought of the age, but also the possibility of a vocation other than that exercised in the domestic domain itself. The great law of the division of labor will also make itself felt for women's education and women's work. While woman within the home — as mother, wife, and sister — could be said to represent what is undividedly human, the enduring wellsprings of intimacy and love, the law of the division of labor and one-sidedness now threatens them as well. Many see in this a great danger for the future of home. But if home is to be capable of solving the task of allowing personal distinctiveness to move more freely than hitherto for the man's part, the corresponding task will also be capable of being solved for the woman's part. Home has so deep and firm a natural foundation that it will certainly endure, even if the hitherto prevailing division of labor between the two sexes is replaced by a different arrangement. Nature has not yet spoken its last word here.

Like everything else in the world, home too must struggle for life. Under very different forms it has hitherto maintained its significance, and it will also in the future be able to demonstrate its great significance: to be at once a world of intimacy and a world of freedom to a far greater degree than any other kind of community is able.